

13 Dance Choreography



Just as a river's flow is directed around rocks and pebbles, choreography shapes the way a dance flows. Choreography is the art of creating and arranging dance movements to form a visual pattern or spectacle. The placement of dancers, their directions, pauses, and movements are decisions choreographers make to bring their vision to life.



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Do you know?

The first known thinker on the idea of choreography in India is Sage Bhārata, the author of the *Nāṭyaśhāstra*. More than 2000 years ago, he described a concept called '*Piṇḍibandhas*', which are group formations characterised by clustering, weaving, linking, and moving in coordinated shapes.

Many of these ancient ideas appear in choreographies even today, such as:

- ◆ group formations and shapes;
- ◆ coordinated travelling patterns; and
- ◆ movement flow in unison or in opposition.



Choreography and Collaboration

In the context of Indian dance, one would use the term '*nṛitya-saṁrachanā*' (dance creation) to refer to dance choreography.

Creating a dance piece involves imagination, planning, teamwork, and the thoughtful use of all the elements and techniques of dance and



Fig. 13.1. Interlinked hands in a dance formation



Fig. 13.2. Circular movement pattern in dance

movement you have learnt so far. A choreographer works collaboratively with the dancers to shape ideas, experiment with movement, and refine them before the final presentation. The soundscape can be instrumental, lyrical, or even silent! The choreographer can choose to match the rhythm or create cross-patterns with rhythm. The possibilities are endless...!

A choreography includes the following:



Concept: A clear subject, story, or theme that the dance will explore (for example, seasons, friendships, journeys, celebrations, emotions, or socially relevant ideas)

Style: The chosen genre of presentation (for example, theatrical, lyrical, fantasy-based, narrative, folk-inspired, or abstract)



Movement Vocabulary: The dance style(s) used in the piece (for example, classical, folk, contemporary, freestyle, or a combination)

Time: Decisions about rhythm, tempo, pauses, and timing that influence the mood and pacing of the choreography



Space: Use of formations, directions, spatial levels, distances between dancers, and patterns across the performance space

Choreographic Tools: Devices such as repetition, contrast, canon, unison, variation, formation changes, mirroring, and the use of props



Practice and Refinement: Rehearsing, editing, and polishing movement sequences to create clarity, synchronisation, and expressive impact

Now, let us explore the two aspects of choreography—movement patterns and use of space.

Movement patterns in choreography

There are infinite ways in which patterns can be created through movement. The process of creating movement patterns can include:

- ◆ linking movements into sequences;
- ◆ designing shapes with the body;
- ◆ arranging dancers into formations; and
- ◆ creating symmetry or asymmetry.

Movement patterns in choreography carry layered meanings, especially within folk traditions. Rooted in everyday life and collective experience, these patterns emerge through simple steps, repetition, and group formations. In Indian regional dances, such movement vocabulary becomes a reflection of community life like shared work, social bonds, and collective celebration expressed through bodies moving together in rhythm.

Human formations, such as pyramids, are commonly seen in several Indian dance forms.



Fig. 13.3. Dance by the Naga Community, Hornbill festival



Fig. 13.4. Mallakhamba from Maharashtra



Fig. 13.5. Karagāṭṭam from Tamil Nadu



Fig. 13.6. Bhangra dance from Punjab

Let us explore

Folk dance movement patterns often resemble patterns from daily life, nature, and the cosmos. What patterns from nature can you take inspiration from for your choreographies?



Fig. 13.7. Bagurumba Butterfly dance from Assam



Fig. 13.8. Manjushree and Ranjabati Chaki Sarkar as Māyā and Prakṛiti in Modern Indian dance (Nava Nritya)

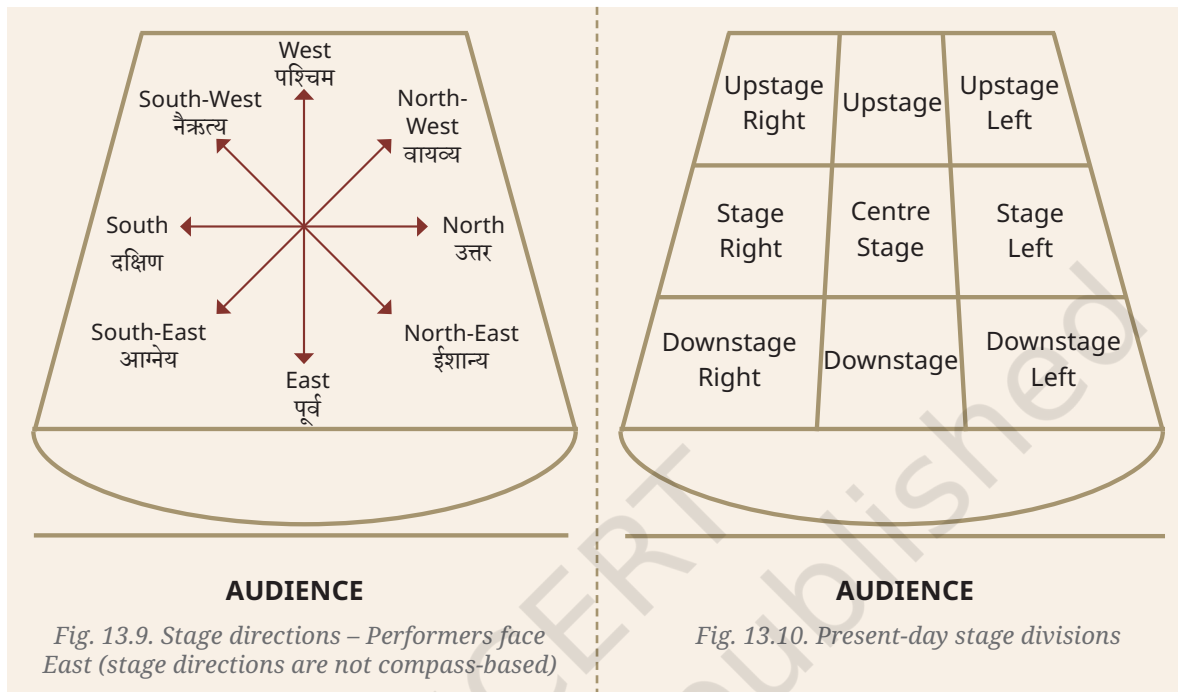
Nava Nritya of Manjushree Chaki Sarkar

Manjushree Chaki Sarkar was trained in Indian dance forms in Kolkata in the 1950s. She later spent several years in the USA, where she was exposed to Western modern and contemporary dance. On returning to India, she felt the need to develop a new contemporary dance vocabulary rooted in Indian aesthetics. Drawing on her background in cultural anthropology, she reimagined her work as **Nava Nritya**, creating a new dance vocabulary based on Indian aesthetics. She was assisted in this work by her daughter **Ranjabati**.

She received the Sangeet Natak Akademi award in 1994.

Spatial usage in choreography

One of the key skills of a choreographer is to understand the dancing space. Mapping the dance floor to make various lines and shapes enables the choreographer to visualise the possibilities of movement patterns.



Activity 13.1

Plan a choreography

Using the diagrams of a stage with markings as shown above, plot where different dancers can position themselves to create different formations. You can choose the number of dancers you would like in your choreography.

This can also be done physically with dancers in your space.

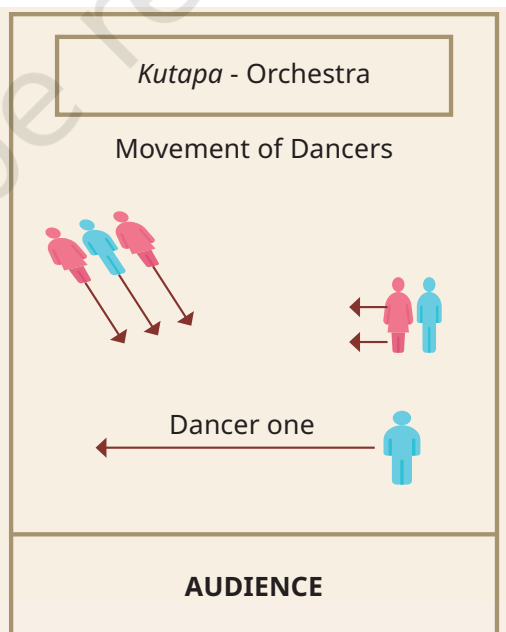


Fig. 13.11. Stage mapping

Activity 13.2

Creating your choreography

Divide yourself into four groups. Choose your lead choreographer.

- ◇ First, each choreographer creates a solo movement portraying a concept of their choice (for example, contemporary theme, or depiction of nature like rain and thunderstorms, or celebration of festivals, etc.). They may choose any movement vocabulary they are comfortable with.
- ◇ Next, each lead choreographer must adapt their solo phrase into a group choreography, exploring formations, spacing, timing, and interaction.
- ◇ The choreography can include aspects of all four *abhinayas*, such as:
 - expressive, stylised movements (use of hand gestures, animation, and mime);
 - rhythmic syllables and spoken word;
 - props; and
 - emotional expression.
- ◇ Each solo choreographer presents their choreography, followed by the group performance of the same.
- ◇ Observe each group's performance and explore how it can change and how expression changes with group interaction and usage of space in a:
 - solo performance; and
 - group performance



Fig. 13.12. Contemporary Kathak choreography



Note to the teacher: The number of lead choreographers, grouping, presentation mode, and occasion, etc., may be decided based on the teacher's or group's discretion. Encourage students to perform their work in class or at a school event.

When we choreograph, we collaborate, and when we create, we connect!’

Activity 13.3

Reflections

Reflect on and analyse the choreography created in Activity 13.2. Review your performance and ask for feedback from your peers and experts. Record it in your dance journal.

- ❖ **Self-Review:** Were you able to communicate your concept clearly through your choreography? What worked well?
- ❖ **Peer Review:** Observe the feedback given by your peers and discuss amongst yourselves.
- ❖ **Expert Review:** Take supportive and constructive feedback from your teacher or an invited expert on the clarity, creativity, and effectiveness of your work.

Activity 13.4

Well-being discussion circle

Prompts may include the following:

- ❖ Now that you have completed your journey with dance and movement this year, discuss your experiences and observations of the various concepts you have learnt and practised.
- ❖ Reflect on your experiences of creating, sharing, and collaborating.

End the circle by identifying your silver lining! Find something positive you discovered about yourself, your group, and the creative process.

Do you know?

आकृत्या चेष्टया चिह्नैर्जात्या विज्ञाय तत्पुनः ।

स्वयं वितर्क्य कर्तव्यं हस्ताभिनयनं बुधैः ॥

— नाट्यशास्त्र, 9.155

Ākṛityā cheṣṭayā chihnairjātyā vijñāya tat-punaḥ ॥

Svayaṁ vitarkya kartavyaṁ hastābhinayanaṁ budhaiḥ ॥

— Nāṭyaśāstra, 9.155

Sage Bharata, the author of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, tells us that once we understand the basics of the form, the movement, and the meaning, we must think creatively and shape it in our own way. The *Nāṭyaśāstra* gives us guidance, but the dancer must bring imagination.

EXERCISES

Q1. Identify any visual patterns you see around you in your daily life. Connect them with signature movements of any regional dance forms. Make a table of the visual patterns and connected dance forms.

Q2. Mention any three dance forms where you see similar visual pattern as in Fig.13.13.

Q3. Draw your choreography mapping with directions of either:

- i. stage settings with musicians, sets, and props; or
- ii. placement and movements of dancers.

Q4. Journal your reflections. Analyse your choreography in your dance journal. Explain your chosen theme, the choreographic patterns, and reason for choosing various dance elements for the choreography.

Q5. You have learnt about *rekha*, or creating beautiful lines. In which dance forms could you identify the geometrical shapes?

Q6. 'Where there is a body, there is dance. Dance begins not with perfection, but with sensitivity to the mover.' Discuss the concept of body inclusivity in dance as per your understanding.

Q7. 'A sculpture captures movement in stillness and dance captures stillness even in movement.' Discuss this statement with your understanding of both Indian and Southeast Asian dances.



Fig. 13.13. Milky Way Galaxy



Practical

- Q8. Put together a movement phrase or a dance sequence with all the elements of dance that you have learnt. Think of your body alignment, breath, shapes, footwork including jumps and spins, and arm movements with hand gestures. Add appropriate rhythmic syllables, keeping in mind rhythm and tempo.
- Q9. Present a group dance with any form that you have explored in class, being mindful about collaboration and coordination.
- Q10. Create a thematic presentation. Be mindful of the various *abhinayas* that you are using. Think about the choreography pattern you are going to use.

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